

reader), let us help. That would translate to: “DOES THIS LOOK LIKE NONSENSE TO YOU?”. Now read the third sentence and the confusion should go away. You see, cryptography is simple! All it takes is a trick up your sleeve and the patience to decode or encrypt a message.

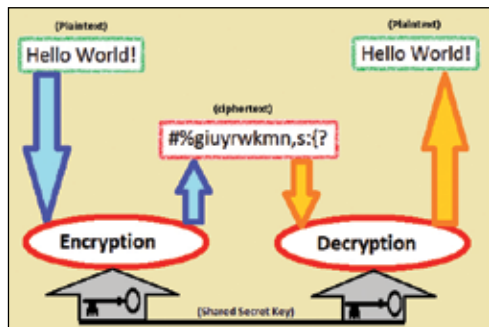
What is Cryptography?

Cryptography is the art and science of converting ordinary information into gibberish and converting it back to its original, meaningful form. It can be done using either simple procedures or very complicated mathematical algorithms. Don't be intimidated by its complexities though. As always, we're here to simplify it for you. And don't forget, you did manage to understand the first code we threw at you, didn't you?

It's amazing how rotating the alphabets by even just one position is enough to confuse the human mind! Oh, and we call it 'rotating', not 'shifting' because shifting would mean having 'Z' replace 'A' as well.

Cryptography involves tricks like there to scramble messages to hide them from unintended audiences. The above example could be easily understood after basic trial and error even if the code breaker didn't have the instructions required to unscramble it. To make it unbreakable, we'll need to employ a sophisticated algorithm. But let's get to that later when you'll be familiarized with some simple algorithms. You'll also learn to create your own small algorithm to encrypt and decrypt data and it's going to be fun.

One of the most prominent secret language systems in India is the famous tapori language well known by Mumbaites. With keywords such as peti, khokha and supari, the language has found wide acceptance in Bollywood movies, especially those revolving around organized crime. Though these words are famous now, they were once known only by street thugs. Notice that the vocabulary consists of actual words from the Hindi language whose meanings differ when used by the seasoned tapori. This is a good example of cryptog-



Symmetric Cryptography